

I Я G33K!

Proud of your geek status? If you're not causing frustration in humans around you, however, you shouldn't be. Here are seven random, pointless things that only true geeks would dare do. Why? Because they can

Nimish Chandiramani

Get Efficient...ish

Did you know that the QWERTY keyboard layout was designed to *slow typists down*? Think about that the next time you think you're hot stuff at 60 words per minute—you could actually be so much faster! The Dvorak keyboard layout is a much more sensible design. A little old lady named Barbara Blackburn set the record for the world's fastest typing speed on a Dvorak keyboard—a peak of 212 words per minute!

Using the Dvorak layout is a security system, too. Try picturing that annoying friend or colleague who treats your PC like his own—now picture him trying to type even the simplest word with a keyboard that isn't QWERTY. From our experiments, we've discovered miscreants who've run away crying like babies.

Sadly, you must also deal with being nearly useless on a QWERTY keyboard and field questions like “Are you *sure* you're a writer?”

Down With Word

Do you really think geeks need features like AutoCorrect and spell check? Do real geeks need anything beyond system fonts? Fancy text editors are for the weak—you, however, must choose between the two text editors to end it all—Vi (or Vim) and EMACS.

The two editors have been around since the glorious days of Unix, and continue to live in our favourite Linux distributions today. Both are keyboard warriors' best friends, and both have fanatical user communities. More importantly, both have that “retro” goodness that only 30-year old programs can have. They are both each other's mortal enemies, and by liking one, you automatically reject the other.

If you're not the Linux type, you can get your hands on the Windows versions as well.

Doing It The Hard Way

Popular applications are for...well...the general population. Who *really* needs all those features anyway? You must transcend bells and whistles, and use programs that are more focused on their primary functions.

In the IM department, shun everything for Miranda—it's a nonsense multi-messenger, devoid of unnecessary fluff (emoicons, for instance). It lets you satisfy your prodding instincts with the multitude of settings, guaranteeing hours of tweaking joy.

Replace your current media player with Foobar. True to its name, it is rather effed up beyond all recognition—the default interface doesn't even have a volume slider—you're supposed to know how to change the volume using The Force (or alternatively, a keyboard shortcut). Another tweaker's pet, Foobar ensures that the second you think you're done configuring it, you'll think of a new thing you can do with it.

DIY

Is your current MP3 player too “assembly line”? Instead of settling for gadgets that the rest of the world's using, build your own! If you're comfortable (or are willing to get comfortable) with C and/or Assembly language programming and can use a soldering iron without burning holes in things—especially yourself—you can get your hands on a number of kits that give you all the components you need to build the gadget of your choice.

This'll usually consist of a microcontroller, a PCB, resistors, capacitors, buttons and so on. Sometimes, you'll even get the code that you need to program the microcontroller with—it's not the same as doing it yourself, but you can take pride in the fact that your MP3 player (or whatever) is the geekiest—even if it doesn't have a display, or a “shuffle” function, or...well, much more than a Play button.

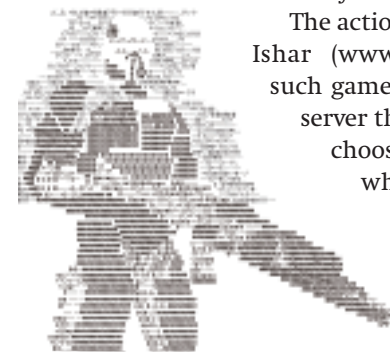


Oblivion? Bah!

Think you're being retro with *Minesweeper* and *Jezzball*? What you *really* need is a good dose of text-based RPG-ing. After all, what gaming engine can match your imagination?

And what, you might ask, is a text RPG? Think of it as any other role-playing game—choose from races like elf, human and so on, build your skills, wreak havoc if you can, try not to get killed, and so on—but instead of roaming the world in a shiny new 3D gaming engine, you do it in a command-line interface. To look around, type “look”, to kill someone, type “kill” and so on. The action is all in your mind's eye.

The action's even gone MMO—Ishar (www.ishar.com) is one such game—you connect to the server through your browser, choose a name, race, and whatnot, and you're plonked into a city called Mareldja, from whence the madness must commence.



Get Back To Your Roots

Warning: while there is a smidgen of value to be obtained from the rest of these activities, this particular one baffles even the best of us. Throw yourself back to the days of Windows 3.1—at the time, wouldn't you have yearned to see it fly on a Pentium III with 512 MB of RAM?

Well, here's your chance. The 8 MB (!) OS is available for download at a couple of abandonware sites (we can't give you their URLs). You'll even find applications for it on those sites, so you could theoretically have all you need to use this every day.



Get On The Mobile (?) Web

What do you do when you want to surf the Internet on your non-WiFi phone? GPRS is too slow, and depending on your provider, can get a bit expensive. You've probably got a perfectly good connection hooked up to your PC—how about using that? Forget, for the moment, that you'll be giving up a perfectly good computer with a large monitor and a full keyboard to squint at your phone's screen—it's the coolness of using the Internet on your phone that matters more.

Just hook up your phone via USB or Bluetooth (assuming you have a Bluetooth adaptor), configure the connection and you can surf the Internet. In bed. Well, if you have Bluetooth. If you're using USB, you can access the Internet from as far as your USB cord will let you go.

nimish.chandiramani@thinkdigit.com

